THREE

Reconciliation

NELL · DAY 23,200 · TUESDAY 21 APRIL 2026

I HAD NINE days of notice left, twelve ledgers, and a keycard that still worked.

The keycard beeped. I looked up before I could stop myself. The red light was on, in its corner above the door, where it had presumably been for years. I went in under it and pulled the roller door down behind me.

A manifest can be doctored. A vehicle log is a different animal. Every lorry, every day: driver, mileage out, mileage in, a one-line job reference, written by men who were tired and wanted to go home. It's the kind of paperwork that only lies about small things. If a lorry had gone to Harrowgate House in 1971, a tired man had written down where.

The 1971 logs were three shelves below the box where I'd found the manifest, in ledgers with marbled covers gone soft as felt. I took down January. Then February. I didn't sit on the crate; I worked standing at the shelf, the ledger open on my forearm, running a finger down the job references. Depot. Depot. Port. Supermarket. Depot.

I didn't stop for lunch. At three a lorry went past on the road outside and I lost my place and had to go back a week. At five the strip light flickered and I worked through it.

March.

Wednesday the third. A round trip, logged in a careful hand, with no job reference at all. Where the reference belonged, he'd written *H.H. — per instr.*

The mileage put the far end about two and a half hours away. Somewhere rural. Somewhere you'd need instructions to find.

I stood very still with the ledger on my arm. Harrowgate House. Per instruction. One run in a whole quarter of runs, to the place on my manifest, and nobody had billed it.

I wrote the date on the back of my hand, because there was nothing else to write on, and put March back on the shelf.

When I let myself out, the red light was off.

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BY THE END of the week the blog had four hundred readers, and I couldn't have told you how. A man explained at length that the stamp was obviously a brand of Victorian fertiliser. A woman wrote *I believe you*, though I hadn't claimed anything. And on the Friday a reader with a cartoon owl for a picture wrote one line:

Could D. 3062 be a count of days? Like a ship's log?

I said *oh* out loud, at the kitchen counter. Eleven years with dates, and a stranger with an owl had seen it in a morning. I was annoyed. I want that on the record.

I did the sum on the back of an envelope: years, leap years, months, remainder, each line checked before I trusted the next. Then on my phone. Then, because I no longer trusted anything I'd only checked twice, by hand again.

The fourteenth of October, 1962.

Somebody had started counting a week before the world held its breath. Anyone old enough remembers that autumn, and everyone younger has seen the documentaries: the week the whole world

sat by its radios to find out whether there would be a next week. And somebody had still been counting, carefully, eight years and four months later.

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ON THE SUNDAY my feet took me past the old head office. It's flats now, the lettering chiselled off the stone. My father worked on the second floor for thirty years. Anyone at Coyle's who'd lost a document, in any year between 1979 and 2009, was told *ask Emmanuel*, and he'd have told them the shelf, the box and the colour of the folder. He did the crossword in pen and never crossed anything out. He'd have done my sum before the kettle boiled.

I took out my phone to ring him, and got as far as his name before I remembered. Seven years, and it still happens. I've never deleted the number. Some days I'm afraid someone will answer.

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THERE WERE TWO retired drivers I still had numbers for. On the Monday I rang them both.

The first one laughed. *Long weather? Sounds like my ex-wife.* We talked about his allotment for twenty minutes.

The second one went quiet.

I'll call him Len, which is nothing like his name. He'd driven for Coyle's for forty-six years. When I said *for the long weather* there was a silence long enough that I thought the line had gone. Then he said he'd seen it on the odd job, and asked after my mum. I told him she'd died, ten years ago. He said he was sorry, he hadn't known, and then he said he'd meet me for a coffee, but not at his house. "The caff by the old depot. Thursday. Ten." He rang off before I could thank him.

That night I did the stupid thing.

I opened the first post and added a paragraph at the bottom, under the questions. I'd asked two retired drivers who knew everything, I wrote. One laughed. The other went quiet, said he'd

seen it on the odd job, and asked about my mum. *I'm not reading anything into that.* And then, because it was midnight and four hundred people were reading me and I was pleased with the line: *(I'm reading something into that.)*

I didn't name him. I didn't name the café. I thought that was being careful.

By the morning forty-one people had read it. I sat with my finger over *delete* for a long time, and didn't press it, because a deletion is the loudest thing you can do on the internet. It would have looked like exactly what it was.

On the Wednesday an email came from the people who used to be Human Resources, reminding me to return all company property on my last day. There was a list: laptop, work phone, lanyard, parking permit. I read it three times. The keycard wasn't on it.

Thursday was the last day of my notice. Nobody asked for the keycard back, and I didn't offer it.

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THE CAFÉ BY the old depot has been about to close since 1985. Formica tables, a laminated menu with photographs the food has never lived up to, a radio playing to itself. Len was already there, in the corner seat with his back to the wall.

He was a big man gone thin: the frame still there, the weight gone somewhere else. He'd parked facing out. He'd taken the seat that saw the door. When I sat, he moved the sugar so it wasn't between us, as if clearing a cab for a passenger. Then he put his phone on the table, face up, with my paragraph on it.

"Bloke at the allotments showed me that," he said. "Tuesday. *Is this you, Len?*"

"I didn't name you."

"You said a driver went quiet." He kept his voice low and level, which was worse than shouting. "How many drivers d'you think went quiet, love? There's about six of us left."

I opened my mouth and nothing useful came out. I was thinking about him. Then, a beat too late and ashamed of it, I was thinking about me. In May I'd signed a settlement with a paragraph about company records in it that I hadn't read twice, and every time I'd gone into that archive my keycard had written my name down.

"I'll take it off," I said.

"Leave it. Taking it off's worse." He turned his phone over. "You learn that."

I slid my own phone across, with the photo of the manifest. He didn't look at it for a long time. Then he held it at arm's length, the way people hold photographs of the dead.

"Twice a year, maybe," he said. "Never on the board. The office'd ring you at home the night before. You'd collect, you'd deliver, and a fella'd meet you at the far end and pay you, separate. Cash. Polite. Good suit. You'd not remember his face after. Not a bad face. Just one that didn't stick."

I asked what he'd carried.

"Machines, mostly." Teletypes, early on. Later, "them fax things". And once, in the eighties, something the size of a wardrobe, in a crate, that took four men to lift, out to the country house the old drivers called H.H. "And it hummed," he said. "With the power off. You could feel it through the seat." He heard himself say it, and looked at his tea as if the tea had been talking.

The door opened.

A man came in and sat at the table next to ours. Ordinary height, an ordinary coat, a newspaper folded under his arm that he put down and didn't open. He ordered a tea. He said please and thank you. He sat facing the window, half turned from us, and looked at the street as if he were waiting for a bus.

Len stopped talking.

He didn't look at the man. He picked up the laminated menu and read it, carefully, though he'd have known it by heart for forty years. Then he told me about his allotment, the same allotment I'd heard about on Monday from the other driver, or one exactly like

it, and I let him, because something in his face had shut like a door.

The man drank his tea. It took about ten minutes. He left a coin on the saucer, picked up his unopened paper and went out, and the bell rang behind him.

Len didn't turn round. He watched the dark strip of window beside the door, where the street showed back to front, until the coat had gone past it. Then he watched a little longer, in case it came back.

It didn't. Nobody got on a bus. There wasn't a stop on that side of the road.

Len put the menu down. "Who else did you tell?"

"Nobody. I didn't say where. I didn't say when."

He looked at me for a long moment. Not angry any more. Something worse: sorry for me.

"Did you know him?" I said.

"Never seen him before," he said. "Couldn't tell you what he looked like."

Neither could I. I tried, later, in the car, with my notebook on the steering wheel, the way I'd describe a load for a manifest: height, build, colour, distinguishing marks. A coat. A newspaper. Please and thank you. That was all I had.

Then, because I couldn't help it, I opened the blog. Forty-one had become three hundred and twelve. Somebody had copied my paragraph, just that one, and posted it on its own from an account with no picture and no name, and no other posts, ever.

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I ASKED LEN about the first run. Harrowgate, 1962.

"Before my time. Old Tommy did it." Len turned his mug a quarter-turn. "Never talked about it, not for years. Then when he got old he never talked about anything else."

"What did he say?"

"Same thing every time. Took a machine out to a big house in the fog, on a Saturday. Seven cars on the drive and no staff to park

them. Fella at the door, no face to speak of, says it'll be *needed from tomorrow*." Len shook his head. "Tommy wrote that on the docket. Nobody'd asked him. Wrote it down so it'd be somewhere, he said, because it bothered him and he'd nowhere else to put it."

I'd been carrying that house around in my bag for ten days, and here, at last, was somebody in it: a young man in a cab, in 1962, with a pencil, putting a thing that bothered him on the only paper he had.

Needed from tomorrow. A machine carried into that house on the Saturday. The counting started on the Sunday.

A man with no face at the door in 1962. A cash man whose face didn't stick in the eighties. A man at the next table whose face I couldn't keep for ten minutes. I made myself stop there.

"Why did you go quiet," I said, "on the phone?"

He lined his mug up with the edge of the table, like a man squaring a stack of paper.

"Because my mate Terry asked," he said. "Back in the eighties. Asked the office who the cash man was. Just asked. Friendly, like." A quarter-turn of the mug. "And then Terry wasn't on long-distance any more. Nothing nasty. Nobody shouted. He just never got the good runs again, and he never asked anything else, ever. Lucky, really, Terry. Lost the good runs and kept his sleep."

He looked at my phone, face down on the Formica, and then at me.

"You asked on the internet, love."

He stood up and put on his coat, which took a while, and left a two-pound coin for his tea even though I'd said I'd pay. At the door he turned round, and I thought he was going to say goodbye.

"You'll notice it now," he said. "That's what I'm telling you. Once you've seen it, that's you. That's the rest of your life."

The bell rang. The radio played to itself. I sat with a cold coffee and my phone face down on the table, and understood that he hadn't been warning me off.

He'd been welcoming me.